

Jenny Hitchings

The 47-year-old is still setting PRs after three decades of running. BY MIKE TYMN

Although she's been running since 1982, when she was in college, Jenny Hitchings has been setting personal bests at 47, an age when one's best times are supposedly well in the past. She ran her marathon best of 2:50:25 at December's California International Marathon, while her half marathon best of 1:21:56 came just a month later, and she notched a 10-mile best of 62:40 in early March. "She still has relatively fresh legs and now has a structured program, something she didn't

have before," Brett Schumacher, her coach, explains. "I don't think she knew what she was capable of until the past few years and now the confidence she has from the progress she has made is driving her even more."

Hitchings agrees. "I didn't really get serious about running until around 2005," she says. "I think I always had natural talent, but I didn't know how to train until then. There was no speed work, tempo runs, energy drinks, gels, or seamless bras."

Although she played a little soccer and was on her high school swimming team for a year, Hitchings didn't give running a try until attending the University of California at Santa Barbara, and that was for fitness purposes, not sport. "A 1-mile run on the beach turned to 5 miles one day, then 9 miles," she says. "I jumped into a few races, but without any training. It was really just to stay fit and because I thrived on how I felt when I was out there and when I was finished." Her first marathon was a 3:55:46 at Los Angeles in 1988.

After joining the Buffalo Chips Running Club, she began meeting other runners, talking with them, learning from them, and seeing the value of having a coach. At the 2005 Vancouver Marathon, she significantly improved her marathon time to 3:09:24, and then broke 3:00 for the first time at Cal International that December with a 2:58:15. She considers the latter race her most memorable, as she had no real expectations of breaking 3:00. "I just couldn't believe it," she says. "I was so proud of myself, and that was the beginning of my marathon streak. I just kept wanting to break 3:00 to prove it wasn't a fluke."

Even though she's running faster times than ever, Hitchings is dealing with the aging process. "I need a little more time to recover as my muscles stay sore longer than they used to," she admits. "My body also feels like it gets out of alignment easier. I need to warm up and cool down longer, and my raw speed may not be what it used to be, if I ever had any. I need to work harder for that faster turnover."

As for the future, Hitchings would like to break 2:50 in the marathon and perhaps even take a shot at the Olympic trials qualifying time of 2:46. "I have a year to qualify," she says. "Why not dream big?" RT



TRAINING REGIMEN

For the 2010 California International Marathon

MONDAY: 60:00 easy (7:30–7:45/mile pace)

TUESDAY: 15:00 warm-up; 6 x 100m strides at 10K pace, followed by increasingly faster strides in sets of 5, 4, 3, 2, 1; 5:00 jog; 2 miles at goal marathon pace; 5:00 jog; repeat the 100m strides; 10:00 cool-down

WEDNESDAY: 60:00 easy

THURSDAY: 15:00 warm-up; 6 x 100m strides; 1 hour at 6:30 pace; 5:00 jog; 5 x 30 seconds fast with 1-minute recovery; 15:00 cool-down

FRIDAY: Rest

SATURDAY: 50:00 easy, plus 10 x 100m strides

SUNDAY: 24-mile long run, "nice and easy"

MONDAY: 60:00 easy

TUESDAY: 15:00 warm-up; 6 x 100m strides; 4 x 2K at goal 10K pace with 2:00 jog recovery; 5:00 jog; 3 miles at goal marathon pace; 6 x 100m strides; 15:00 cool-down

WEDNESDAY: 60:00 easy

THURSDAY: 80:00 progression run. Start very easy, work pace down to half marathon pace at the end; 4 x 100m easy strides

FRIDAY: Rest

SATURDAY: 10:00 jog; 6 x 30 seconds fast, with full recovery; 5:00 jog

SUNDAY: Half marathon race

BORN: July 1, 1963
LIVES: Sacramento, CA

PERSONAL BESTS

5K: 18:22

10K: 39:00

10 MILES: 62:40

HALF MARATHON: 1:21:56

MARATHON: 2:50:25



STATS